long-term benefits and control over raw materials in the global sense'. In the absence of control over raw materials, reliance on imported inputs made the company's growth unpredictable, says Menon. This was one of the key reasons why Ratan spared no effort in expanding inorganically and acquiring foreign assets.

In the midst of all these business endeavours, social issues and problems weighed heavily on Ratan's mind. He was perturbed by the reality that waterborne diseases were a serious threat to the health and well-being of the marginalized segments of society who did not have access to clean drinking water. To find a solution, a low-cost highly efficient water purifier that did not require electricity to run was developed jointly by Tata Chemicals, TCS and Titan in 2009. With a cost of less than Rs 1,000, Tata Swach used 'natural materials and cutting edge nanotechnology'. The product was launched by Tata Chemicals. At its launch, Ratan said, 'The quest is not to create the cheapest products. Our focus is on accessing the largest number of people.'

Ratan's strategy to grow in the agricultural segment also saw Tata Chemicals venturing into branded pulses in 2010, a move that would again benefit the underprivileged who required quality staples but could not afford high-cost products.

In 2011, following a spate of overseas acquisitions, the company announced a major rebranding exercise by bringing its global subsidiaries under the Tata Chemicals corporate brand. This led to General Chemical Industrial Products being rebranded as Tata Chemicals North America, Brunner Mond (UK) as Tata Chemicals Europe, Brunner Mond (SA) as Tata Chemicals South Africa and Magadi Soda as Tata Chemicals Magadi.

During the same year, the company acquired British Salt, a leading UK-based vacuum salt producer. The acquisition further deepened Tata Chemicals' 'presence in the food and farm sectors' and provided the company with an 'opportunity to secure long-term brine supplies' for Brunner Mond's operations.

At the company's AGM in 2011, Ratan rolled out another plan. It was a 'capital expenditure plan of Rs 800 crore over the next three years'. It was a logical next step to the spate of acquisitions that the company had made.

The year 2012 saw Ratan stepping down as chairman of Tata Chemicals. By then, the company had expanded its business within India and abroad. Its turnover had risen to Rs 14,711 crore in 2013, registering a growth of